



"The Indian Open Source Space is Still Evolving"

Bagisto is an open source e-commerce platform built on Laravel. **Saurav Pathak, VP-product and sales, Bagisto Webkul**, in an exclusive interaction with **Sreejani Bhattacharyya of Open Source For U**, talks about his open source journey and the challenges he faced. He also airs his views on the current open source landscape in the country.

Saurav Pathak, VP-product and sales, Bagisto Webkul

Saurav Pathak was introduced to the open source ecosystem during his tenure at Webkul. He says, "The foundation of Webkul was laid on open source technologies from the very first day. We have been regularly contributing to the open source community, organising events and even funding open source projects. 'Kul' refers to a community; so the word 'Webkul' means an online community. Open source is in our DNA. Webkul is the single biggest company from India working across 22 platforms, 90 per cent of which are open source."

Bagisto is the first open source project that Pathak is directly involved with and currently working on. This open source e-commerce platform, built on Laravel, has been created to help developers and merchants looking to set up an e-commerce platform on MVC based architecture easily get their online shop infused with the latest tech stack and innovative features.

Many challenges encountered

But building this application did come with challenges. Pathak says, "Open source is all about community. The application can only succeed if a good number of community developers can easily adopt it, customise it for their use, and further build extensions or plugins for

it. Then, it's also important that industry leaders and companies recognise it, and start using it for their customers."

Another important issue is partnership. Partnering with different companies, events or developer communities across geographical regions helps in spreading the word through meetups, conferences, hackathons, etc. These act as points of contact and help people in their region adopt the application.

Investor backing is also crucial to building and growing a project. Pathak points out, "Since open source is all about giving back to the community, revenue does not generally come into the picture. Most open source applications run based on donations as part of a good gesture. But that is also one of the toughest parts of running open source. When the application does not turn out as expected, many companies move into providing services and, eventually, the application gets stuck."

Pathak adds that search rankings do affect getting organic and inorganic traffic to your application. If you are providing a specific application and if the community cannot find you on the Google search engine, you are certainly losing a lot of potential customers.

What was the inspiration behind Bagisto? Pathak says that the aim was to build an e-commerce application, but a lot

of brainstorming went into whether to build an open source or SaaS model and what framework to build it on. The choice was to either start from scratch or use an existing framework that attracted community developers to easily extend and build custom solutions on Bagisto.

Hottest technologies were used to develop Bagisto

It was decided to make use of the technologies that are most popular amongst developers, have a wide community reach, are MVC based and, most importantly, are easy to use and customise. That's how Laravel and Vue.js were used.

On October 31, 2018, Bagisto was officially launched in the open source ecosystem. Two years on, it has 3000+ GitHub Stars, 30,000+ downloads, 80+ contributors, a 200k+ user base, two active communities running in Brazil and Belgium, and 1500+ members. Pathak says, "We build together with a partner, Bagisto-Europe, located in Belgium. This is a point of contact for partners and customers in the EU region and also offers 24/7 support."

Bagisto has been featured in various media like *Laravel News*, *Times of India*, *itsFOSS*, and *OpenSourceForU.com*, to name a few. Bagisto has also featured in the keynote talks at IndiaOS2020 and Open Source India.

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